

Walking through an apartment you might rent

8 findings · 13-step checklist · 1 myth · 8 sources · cheatgrid.com

One viewing gives you a take shaped by your mood, the order you saw places in, and how much trouble getting there took. Naming those out loud **weakens their pull**.

THE GOAL

You're separating what the place actually offers from what's coloring your read of it. Write down what you notice in each room while you're still standing in it.

CHECKLIST

You've just stepped inside and started walking through, forming your first take on the place.

- ☐ Before you step past the doorway, **say your mood** in a few words, like "tired" or "in a hurry."
- ☐ If you haven't toured another apartment yet today, label this rating as provisional.
- ☐ As you walk into each room, say out loud whatever grabs your attention, good or bad, in a few words.
- ☐ In every room, open the cupboards, closets and any storage, and check what's really inside them.
- ☐ Try the taps and the light switches in each room as you walk through it.
- ☐ Rate this room on your phone before you leave it, not after you've seen the whole place.
- ☐ Photograph or note each room together with the building's name or the unit number, on the same page.
- ☐ Write your rating and notes for this room before making small talk with whoever's showing you around.
- ☐ When they answer something, ask them to **say more** about that one detail, instead of moving to your next prepared question.
- ☐ Before you leave, walk back through any room you moved through quickly, and name one thing in it you skipped.
- ☐ Write down the one thing in the place that would lower your score, before you forget it.
- ☐ Give the whole place one score, using the same scale you'll use for every other place this search.
- ☐ If you're seeing another place today, name one thing you want it to beat this one on, before you get there.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Your mood on viewing day can leak into how you rate the place, and just naming it **weakens the pull**.
- 2** Write down what you notice in each room, right then, before your memory starts **flattering** whichever place you choose.
- 3** How much trouble this viewing took, rearranging your day or driving across town, can make you like the place more once you're standing in it, independent of the apartment itself.

What's quietly swaying your take

KNOW

Order isn't merit: in one study, people's snap, gut-level pick favored whichever option came first, even by seconds. That edge disappeared once people compared deliberately instead of on instinct.

People's snap, gut-level reactions favored whichever option came first, but that edge disappeared once they compared deliberately instead of on instinct. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Your mood on viewing day can leak into how you rate the place, and just naming it **weakens the pull**.

People in a good mood rated something as unrelated as the weather more favorably, an effect that faded once they noticed their own mood. [Source 2](#)

WATCH

Liking a place more the second time you see it doesn't mean you've learned anything new about it. Simple familiarity, on its own, is enough to make almost anything feel better.

Just seeing the same thing again and again was enough on its own to improve people's attitude toward it, no new information required. [Source 3](#)

Getting a straighter read while you're there

KNOW

Trusting your gut is not the safer bet. A structured check **beats gut impression** on average.

A large review of decisions across many fields found working from a short structured list did as well as, or better than, people's overall impression. [Source 4](#)

DON'T

Don't let the small talk shift your notes. A large review found that adding an unstructured interview to expert judgment made predictions worse, not better, across many kinds of decisions.

A large review found expert predictions worsened, not improved, once an interview with the person being judged entered the mix. [Source 4](#)

DO

Ask a real follow-up question that builds on something they just said, not only a question off your prepared list. It won't make you look difficult.

People who asked more follow-up questions in a live conversation were consistently better liked by whoever they were talking to. [Source 5](#)

Your own stake in today's visit

DO

Write down what you notice in each room, right then, before your memory starts **flattering** whichever place you choose.

People who chose between a pair of rental houses later credited the option they picked with good features it never had. [Source 6](#)

KNOW

How much trouble this viewing took, rearranging your day or driving across town, can make you like the place more once you're standing in it, independent of the apartment itself.

Going through something unpleasant to gain access made people rate what they found there higher, even though it was **identical for everyone**. [Source 7](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

A place that's staged or freshly done up really is a better find than a similar one left as-is, not just better presented.

ACTUALLY

People shown the exact same rooms, furnished or empty, didn't change what they'd pay for the home. Only how livable and appealing it felt to them changed, **not its worth** to them. [Source 8](#)

Sources

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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Renting a place at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)